

British airmen, Captain John Alcock and Lieutenant Arthur Whitten Brown, in a modified Vickers Vimy bomber (see panel, right).

As with the long-distance races of the pre-World War I era, such flights could be taken either as revealing the potential of aviation or underlining its shortcomings. For instance, in 1919 the Australian government put up a prize of £10,000 (about \$50,000) for the first of their countrymen to fly from Britain to Australia in under 30 days. The prize was won by brothers Ross and Keith Smith, who, with two other crew members, flew a Vickers Vimy the distance of around 12,000 miles (20,000km) in 27 days 20 hours. They were congratulated by Winston

Churchill, then Britain's Secretary of State for air, in a telegram: "Well done. Your great flight shows conclusively that the new element has been conquered for the use of man."

But of the five aircraft that set out on the Australia flight, the Smiths' was the only one to arrive. Four airmen lost their lives in the attempt and another three narrowly escaped death. The Smiths themselves survived some uncomfortable moments, especially when their aircraft clipped the tops of trees taking off from a too-short racecourse in Rangoon, Burma. Clearly the "new element" was far from being conquered, although its challenge was being heroically confronted.

It was not surprising that many people still considered airships to have better potential for long-range passenger transportation. In July 1919, for example, the British airship R 34, a close copy of a captured German zeppelin, flew across the Atlantic from Scotland to Mineola, New York, and back with 31 people on board. It showed that airships were still well ahead in load-carrying, if not in speed – the outward leg of the R 34's journey, against headwinds, took four and a half days.

RETURN TICKET

On July 13, 1919, the British military airship R 34 set off on the first two-way transatlantic crossing, carrying 31 people (including one stowaway) from Scotland to New York and back in a total flying time of under eight days.



NON-STOP ACROSS THE ATLANTIC

ON JUNE 14, 1919, two British airmen, Captain John Alcock and his navigator, Lieutenant Arthur Whitten Brown, took off from a grass airstrip in St. John's, Newfoundland, in a modified Vickers Vimy bomber. Their goal was to win the *Daily Mail* newspaper's £10,000 prize for the first nonstop flight across the Atlantic. Some 1,890 miles (3,040km) of ocean separated them from Ireland, the nearest landfall to the east. Traveling in an open cockpit, deafened by the racket of the engines, and with only sparse and unreliable instruments, the journey was a test of endurance for the airmen as well as their machine. As bad luck would have it, they also ran into some awful weather. At one point, flying through turbulent storm clouds with zero visibility, disoriented and blinded by lightning flashes, they span down to barely 100ft (35m) above the ocean before emerging from the clouds just in time for Alcock to regain control and pull up above the waves. Hail and heavy snow battered and froze the airmen; Brown had to climb onto the wings to deice the engines with a pocket knife. After 16 hours battling the elements, Alcock and Brown were exhausted and short on hope when a dark line of shore grew faintly visible through the gray mist. They descended over Galway, Ireland, and landed inelegantly nose-down in a soft Irish bog at 9:40 am on June 15. The airmen were given a hero's welcome in London and were later knighted.

SOFT LANDING

Alcock and Brown's Vickers Vimy ended its epic nonstop crossing by crash-landing in Derrygimla bog near Clifden, Galway, on June 15, 1919.



A HERO'S WELCOME

Alcock and Brown paraded through London in the back of an automobile after making the first non-stop transatlantic flight, from Newfoundland to Galway, Ireland, in 16 hours 27 minutes. For Alcock triumph was brief: he was killed in an air crash six months later.

